



POLITICAL TREATY: Yechury and Mukherjee ment was yet to be completed. Another meeting of the UPA-Left nuclear panel is scheduled for next month but, according to sources in the Left, the Congress has stopped hoping for the treaty's execution any time soon.

The Left has spelt out its strategy in a newly published CPI(M) booklet, 'Policy Interventions by the Left Parties'. "Once the draft safeguards agreement is brought before the UPA-Left committee, the Left will take the stand that the Government should not proceed further to finalise the safeguards agreement or go to NSG," it said.

Mukherjee's Washington visit would be rendered ineffective as the Left said that it "will ensure that the nuclear deal does not go ahead". The Congress now needs an honourable way out.

by Satarupa Bhattacharya

Buying Time For a Stricken Deal

DELHI External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee treated UPA and Left leaders to tea and snacks at his residence on March 17 on the pretext of discussing the Indo-US nuclear cooperation agreement. Although the UPA-Left committee—

created to deal with the contentious bilateral treaty—had met after three months, Mukherjee spoke little on its outcome. "Committee members felt that further discussion was needed," he said, while CPI(M) leader Sitaram Yechury, who is

also a member of the nuclear panel, stood watchfully beside.

Mukherjee has been working on a draft safeguards agreement with the IAEA but he did not share the contents with Left leaders at the meeting saying that the docu-

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

After the new airport at Hyderabad was inaugurated, the Congress assured the Left that flights won't operate from there. With Parliament going into recess, the party may show spine as it will not have to fear parliamentary retribution.

VOICES



"The Government of India recognises Tibet as a part of China. This policy has been there even before the Dalai Lama came to India."

Sitaram Yechury, CPI(M) leader

"The Left parties are expectedly not condemning the Chinese acts (in Tibet). The Communist Party is always more bothered about China's interest than India's."

Vijay Kumar Malhotra, BJP leader

"If the Government (at the Centre) falls, it will not be because of us (the Left)."

Prakash Karat, CPI(M) general secretary

"It is a shame that Parliament has not attempted to pass a resolution to condemn China's war against the Tibetans meant to destroy them, their culture, language and religion."

George Fernandes, NDA convener

"Life in confinement has left me half-dead. I plan to leave India though I would like to come back some day. As of now, I cannot take it any more."

Taslima Nasreen, exiled Bangladeshi writer

